CAREER GLITCH · SHORT · SIMPLE · NO BORING PARTS

PRESCHOOL TEACHER IN THE AI ERA

Same licence as the elementary classroom next door. Roughly $25K a year less for holding it with smaller children.

★ TL;DR — NO — as a starting seat. The BLS median is ~$38K, and the track that hires beginners (childcare centers, 65% of the jobs) medians $36,850. The better-paid track demands the same bachelor's plus licence as elementary teaching — which pays $63,820. This roadmap is the way to the better seat, not into the trap. ★

THE CAREER GLITCH TAKE

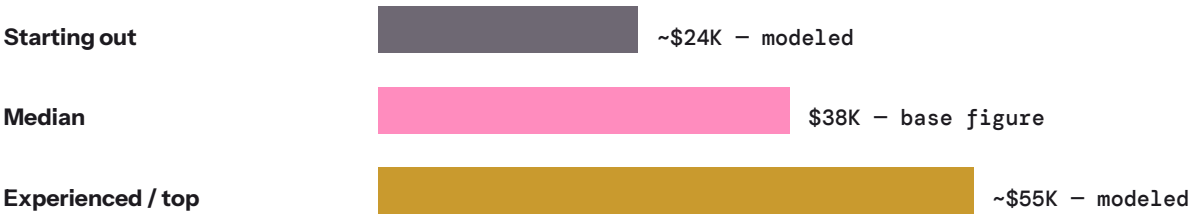
OUR TAKE: NO — NOT IN 2027

MEDIAN ~$38K · TRAINING 1-2 years · AI RISK LOW · CERTIFICATE

- Fails on arithmetic, not on AI: the work is ratio-mandated and in person — no tool can legally sit in your chair.
- The pay split is the story: childcare centers $36,850, public pre-K $52,800, elementary $63,820 — the same licence buys the highest of the three.
- Hiring is easy (+4%, ~66,700 openings a year) because the seat churns: a bottom decile under $28,990 pushes people out.

The site's take, built from this profession's numbers in the Career Glitch base.

THE MONEY — LOOK AT THE BARS



The Career Glitch base figure for Preschool Teacher is a ~$38K median (compiled from U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics, Occupational Outlook Handbook ranges). The starting and top bars are modeled around that median — orientation, not a promise. Pay swings hard by state, employer and experience: check live postings in your state before planning around any number.

WHAT DOES A PRESCHOOL TEACHER ACTUALLY DO?

- ✓ Running circle time, stories, songs and play-based learning
- ✓ Managing meals, naps, bathroom runs and a dozen transitions a day
- ✓ Setting up activities and resetting the room constantly
- ✓ Updating parents and documenting each child's day

Think: a ringmaster of tiny people — every minute is crowd control and wonder at the same time.

WHAT AI ALREADY TOOK (AND WHAT IT CAN'T)

THE ROBOT	THE HUMAN
Scheduling, billing, parent messaging and progress-note apps are software now. The admin fringe shrinks; the mandated number of adults in the room does not.	Ratio-mandated, hands-on care of small children. The law requires a qualified adult physically present — attachment, safety and real-time judgment are the job.

⚠ **THE DOMINATED SEAT: this job will hire you tomorrow — that's the trap. The center track pays a $36,850 setting median while you fund the credentials, and the public pre-K track charges full degree-and-licence price for a $52,800 median. Easy to enter, expensive to stay in.**

THE VIBE — IS THIS YOUR LIFE?

THE JOB IS	THE JOB IS NOT
✓ Your workday is play, songs and small people ✓ Deep bonds with kids and families ✓ Districts competing for licensed teachers	✗ Years of degree work before the real paycheck ✗ Noise, germs and constant motion ✗ Paperwork that follows you home

Good fit? You love small children and have the stamina for them — and the sense to sell that stamina where it's paid.

Bad fit? You planned to stop at the first credential that gets you hired. That is exactly the seat this map routes around.

THE FORK — PICK ONE DOOR

DOOR A — PIVOT TO SCHOOL TEACHER (ELEMENTARY)	DOOR B — PIVOT TO SPECIAL EDUCATION TEACHER

The same bachelor's plus state licence the public pre-K track already demands — pointed at the seat that pays for it. Elementary teachers median $63,820 (BLS), with ~99,400 openings a year and a documented shortage of unfilled and under-certified positions behind them. If a degree is in your future anyway, buy the version of it that comes with the bigger paycheck. First move: choose an accredited elementary-education program — or alternative certification if you already hold a bachelor's — instead of a preschool-only credential.	The hardest classroom seat in America to fill: 74% of elementary and middle schools could not fill a special-education vacancy with a fully certified teacher (NCES), with shortages in 48 states plus Puerto Rico and DC. Median $67,170, ~37,100 openings a year, the same bachelor's-length gate as elementary. First move: an education degree with a special-education endorsement — districts recruit you before you graduate.

Smart move: If you're already in a childcare center, let the job fund the pivot: work the room by day, take the bachelor's in the evenings, and let the center years become your classroom experience — not your ceiling.

Where you land after: An elementary or special-education classroom: the same licence family as pre-K, a real shortage behind you, and a median in the mid-$60Ks instead of the high $30Ks.

YOUR ROADMAP — 6 STEPS

1	2	3	4	5	6
SKIP THE	MAP THE	ENTER THE	CLASSROOM TIME	STUDENT TEACHING	TAKE THE

STEP 1 — Skip the dominated seat

FREE · TODAY

- Compare the three medians before you enrol anywhere: $38,140 preschool vs $63,820 elementary vs $67,170 special education
- If you work in a center now, keep the job — it's income and experience, not the destination

STEP 2 — Map the licence once

FREE · WEEK 1

- Pull your state's elementary and special-education licence requirements — one bachelor's covers the gate
- If you already hold any bachelor's, check alternative certification: every state runs a route for degree-holders

STEP 3 — Enter the degree built for the better seat

TUITION · YEAR 1

- Enrol in elementary education or special education, not a preschool-only program
- Substitute-teach and assistant work count: districts hire people they've already watched

STEP 4 — Classroom time — YEARS 1-3

- Take field placements in the district you want to work in
- In special education, learn the IEP paperwork early — it's half the job

STEP 5 — Student teaching + exams — FINAL YEAR

- Complete student teaching and your state's general and subject exams
- Pass the background check and file the licence application

STEP 6 — Take the seat that pays for the licence — FINAL MONTHS

- Apply to elementary or special-ed classrooms — shortage subjects get hired first
- Negotiate on the district schedule: your step placement is the negotiation

FIRST 90 DAYS — JUST DO THIS

□ Today: write the three medians on one line — $38K / $64K / $67K. That's the whole decision.

□ Days 1–30: licence requirements mapped; program or alternative-cert route chosen.

□ Days 31–60: enrolled or in the alt-cert pipeline; substitute and assistant shifts started if you're not already employed.

□ Days 61–90: first classroom placements booked; exam dates on the calendar.

□ Day 90: you're on the road to the licensed seat that pays — not parked in the one that doesn't.

NEXT — MAKE IT PERSONAL

This roadmap is the same for everyone. Your life is not.

- Not sure this career fits YOU? Take the Big Career Test — 50 questions, your top-3 matches and one honest “probably NOT you”. → careerglitch.com/#test
- Already sure? Turn AI into Your Personal Career Mentor — a 2,300-word system that interviews you first, checks your hours, budget and deadline honestly, and builds YOUR plan into a Notion dashboard. → careerglitch.com/#prompt

★ **SAME LICENCE. BIGGER PAYCHECK.** ★